

Political voice

It is necessary to have a voice and be able to make it heard in a written piece of text because it attracts the reader and makes them listen to what you have to say. The reader may even think about what you are saying, thus establishing your voice's importance in this world. It seems obvious to me. What appears to be more interesting is whether politics plays a part in conveying a message and if one should include their political opinion in a text written about something not directly connected to politics.

The most important thing right now would be to define politics. When first asked what politics was, I felt confused. I felt stunned and was unable to express my thoughts. I could not do so due to the comprehensive nature of the politics itself. It's a terrifyingly essential part of our lives which influences each area of our existence. Politics is everywhere, and almost every decision is based on it. How I see it is politics deals with the distribution of power over people and their decisions, thus, it seems quite impossible not to include a political opinion into an essay if you want your voice to be heard. When I say "political opinion," I do not intend to make it appear as if I am talking about public politicians and their petty feuds. Real politics does not happen in the Oval Offices or Kremlins; no, it happens on our streets, at our houses and heads. I think politics truly achieves its goal when someone makes a decision, no matter how small or big, for themselves and takes power over their bodies without hurting the existence of others. However, it might be extremely challenging, or even impossible, for people to have the autonomy and authority over their choices. Thousands of injured little and young girls and women who had to go through painful genital mutilation had no say in it, and thousand still do not. Reproductive rights are being debated every day by people who should not even have a say in it because those matters do not affect them at all, thus taking away a woman's autonomy and her voice.

I am afraid if I start to list all of the marginalized groups around the world and the kinds of oppression they have to face, I will simply start crying. What I was trying to say is that the lives of some people still depend on someone else's decisions. That is why it is impossible for such persons not to intertwine their existence and their voices with politics because this is how they fight for their autonomy. If you do not have to include your political opinion in your essays, I would conclude you are a lucky person. Just as having and expressing a voice might be a privilege, so might be not having to express it at all. The existence of many groups of people and whether they should have basic human rights, such as a right to marry or a right of expression, a right to social protection, or a right to education, have become a political debate, so people are never allowed to omit their political opinions. Do I include my political opinion into my essays? Yes, it would be a privilege not to.

Speech as an action

In one of her most prominent works which is “Human Condition” philosopher Hannah Arendt represents types of human activities. One of those types is action which consists both of action itself and speech. Arendt states that “without the accompaniment of speech, action would not only lose its revelatory character, but it would lose its subject” claiming that speech is an essential tool for humans to “show who they are, ... and make their appearance in the human world.” After the repetition of similar phrases, it can be seen and clearly understood that the central thought is that an action is not an action unless accompanied by speech. But what if, to say, the speech was not accompanied by action? Will it even exist then and carry any weight?

I believe it will if said speech is itself an action. Words as in speech have power which not all people understand. Many seem to underestimate their influence on individuals and their behavior. The particular choice of wording, just as “acting and speaking” in Arendt’s philosophy, reveals a person’s unique identity “remaining hidden from the person.” Not only the art of the right wording, but the choice of a word itself is a skill that must be acquired not to only be successful (no matter how one would define ‘success’) but to be a respectful human being, to show kindness and plain decency. One can only be humane when one can acknowledge the emotional, historical, political weight certain words carry. American writer James Baldwin in his essay “Stranger in the Village” described just how much pain and sorrow words can bring even when the doer, as Arendt would say, does not even know what connotations such words have: “The children who shout Neger! have no way of knowing the echoes this sound raises in me. I mutter sourly to myself, exactly as I muttered, when I was no bigger than these children are now: Your mother was a nigger.” One word might incite strong negative emotions, bring back fear, anger, pain, and one must always do their best to avoid using such words. Speech, in this case, is itself an action.

Just as action accompanied by speech in Arendt’s text discloses the “agent” or the doer of the deed, so too ‘active words’, words that are action in its nature, disclose the character of a speaker. In addition to such disclosure, ‘active words’ reveal the societal and historical assumptions about the person whom the words are directed at, and also the society itself. Usage of such words goes to show how society is developing and changing – what used to be a norm among oppressors is now unacceptable in a world that claims that all people are equal. Vice versa, some words that were derogatory are now used by both the oppressed and the oppressor, but some people are not quite comfortable reclaiming hurtful words that were used against them or people like them in the past. English actress Sharon D. Clarke in an interview with Gay Times said that “I will always classify myself as gay, as opposed to queer. I think that is because of growing up in a generation where queer was such a derogatory word. I personally won’t use queer because the minute I say it, all my vibrations go back to what queer meant and I’d rather not have that vibration

in my life.” On the contrary, British doctor Ranjit Singh in the same interview proposes a completely different view on reclaiming the word queer: “Reclaiming words of pain and using them for power is vital if we are to grow as a society. Queer, to me, now means the freedom to express yourself and to express your love in a way that you choose. It represents progress.” The comparison of these two quotes shows just how divided the opinions on such important matter are, therefore, one should not only actively disclose themselves with speech and action, but one must also listen to speech of others and acknowledge their actions.

Speech and action are inseparable. Even if no apparent action is performed, speech is still screaming action. If no speech is spoken, action is still telling a story. I would have to disagree with Hannah Arendt since there is no such a thing as speechless action, any speech will always be accompanied by speech, the only difference is how we define the speech and action in question. Words that speech is composed of shall always be an action themselves since they disclose the person’s way of thinking, their preferences, their motivation, and reasons to say certain things. It is really hard to hide behind the words, although some people have mastered the craft which only shows the real intimidating power of speech. Different pejoratives targeted at ethnic and social minorities are another way of using words – as in to incite fear, insult and degrade people which begs the question of what constitutes the socially accepted behavior and how heavily we should rely on speech do the deed for us without understand the power it holds. The world is changing, so does speech. We should be quick to realize the importance of speech, but at the same time remember the importance of filtering out particular words or phrases, or rather control our flow of speech that tells the wrong story, the story which agonizes the people. How we do it is another serious question. Partially, it could be achieved if people learnt that they do not have to understand one’s experience, history, and background to respect them. It is only expected that a white person will never understand what a black person has to go through and why certain words carry so much weight. A straight cisgender person will never walk in the shoes of a queer person, and it is only understandable why. The action of respecting someone without trying to aggressively make them explain themselves would result in an act of speech that is not harmful and ignorant. Why many people fail to realize that remains a mystery.

References:

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The Other within the Self

People live in the world of superficially created binary oppositions: women vs. men, black people vs. white people, the rich vs. the poor, the sick vs. the healthy, etc. Such oppositions are the creator of confusion, oppression, hate, anger, and, as a result, complete chaos in society and its people's minds. To be the Other in this system of beliefs and principles is to be the lesser one, the less fortunate, and less worthy of humanity and a right to live & simply exist. The terrors brought on this planet by this division are still present in the society and are upheld by governmental laws and/or collective intelligence which rules over a group of people whether they form a country's nation, a small village population, or a shop's staff. Otherness characterizing people from a negative perspective brought centuries of slavery and systemic racism, gay bashing and institutionalized homophobia, it made the world an inaccessible place for people with disabilities and turned living into a continuous fight for existence for the less financially fortunate persons. What is even more dangerous (although it seems to be impossible to imagine something even worse) is the opposition and confrontation between the personality of a person, the identity of the Self and their body, physical attributes, desires, social identity. Ideally, all components of a being must be in sync. However, humans are complex creatures, and the union of a body, mind, and soul is extremely hard to be achieved. A human's personality is split into parts, thus the Other within the One is born. What disunites the thought-to-be union of a thought-to-be 'measure of all things'? Humans are a social species that has to cooperate to survive which makes the society the means of sustaining life and yet the same society is at fault for destroying the healthy ecosystem within oneself. Societal norms made up for society's benefits damage people's perception of the Self, create the Other and force the two to collide destroying everything in a mile's radius.

People are perceived in society, thus they are expected to be perceived in a certain way. It creates a fruitful environment for any kind of confusion within oneself and society. For instance, many people assume the heterosexual orientation of a person because it is expected of the said person. When those expectations are not to be met, violence and resentment may take their place. Homophobic attitudes dictate the way our society operates and decide who may live happily ever after and who does not deserve to enjoy the life of a free person. In the places with higher levels of homophobia non-straight individuals tend to experience internalized homophobia. When one is raised constantly listening to their family, friends, distant relatives, people on the media talking about how 'unnatural', or 'wrong' and 'sinful' homosexual attraction is, one is much more likely to hate and reject themselves if they start to experience attraction to the people of the same gender themselves. A 2017 study revealed a high prevalence of internalized homophobia among homosexual men in Southwest China where 'social attitudes toward male homosexuality are still

not optimistic.’[Xu, Zheng, Xu, 2017] More than 30% of the respondents ‘wished they were not gay/bisexual men, would like to be heterosexual.’ Internalized homophobia is built upon societal norms that reject any notion of homosexuality being as valid and righteous as heterosexuality. Individuals with internalized homophobia are driven by their self-hatred towards things that are viewed as socially acceptable, for example, some may engage in a heterosexual relationship and ‘choose opposite-sex marriage to ease the stress of being members of this [homosexual] minority.’ An example of that would be the relationship of Ennis Del Mar and Jack Twist in the American movie *Brokeback Mountain*. [Ang Lee, 2005] One of the characters, Ennis, was a victim of internalized homophobia – he repressed his true identity and gave up the life with a loved one. He feared for his life and made a choice in favor of self-hatred than external homophobia he would have faced otherwise. How exactly could society benefit from it? We see nothing but ruined and destroyed lives of people who are left damaged and fearful. Higher institutions such as the church and the government profit off such people by using them as an example of what a person should never do: as if those institutions lecture its citizens ‘A man must be with a woman, otherwise you will be damaged.’ As a result, the church gains more influence among the common folk, and the government now may use its homophobic propaganda to gain support among its homophobic citizens. Together, these two [the Church and the State] are united in power over their constituents. An example of that would be the enactment of amendments to the Constitution of Russian on July 1, 2020. President Putin proposed an amendment that would define marriage as a relationship between one man and one woman, thus constitutionally banning same-sex marriage. Of course, it would be outrageous if a country that claims to be one of the best countries in the world suddenly denied a handful of its citizens a right to exercise a right to marry. However, such a union had never been allowed in that country to begin with, then why would the government propose such an amendment? Homophobia is a known political strategy to ‘bolster legitimacy, increase popularity and distract from pressing social ills.’ [Reid, 2015] To ensure the efficiency of this tactic, the higher institutions and the society have to completely impair one’s image of the Self and create an alternate Other within a human being. Even external homophobia uses the same building mechanism – one has to make someone frustrated enough to care to an extent of murder what others do with their own lives.

Homophobia in all its forms and shapes is only one of the many ways to separate a person from their identity, in addition, not the most powerful one. It is much more ‘impressive’ to at least try to dissolve the self-awareness of half of the world’s population. Women are born into the society that has prepared beforehand judgments on how a woman should look like, what she must do, and whom she has to belong to: first to a father, then to a husband. Simone de Beauvoir argues that women ‘are defined as relative to the man’ [de Beauvoir, 1979] in one of her best-known

books *The Second Sex*. She quotes French essayist Julien Benda who calls a woman ‘the incidental, the inessential.’ Once again, a very fruitful environment for girls’ and women’s self-doubt and misogyny to rise and take hold over their perception of the Self. At the beginning of her work, de Beauvoir proposes the question ‘What is a woman?’ striving to show that those who deem themselves superior try to define women and set a standard which all women must follow. In order to resist such tension, some women dedicate their lives to fighting the unjust and prejudiced system. However, the efforts to make someone feel alienated with their own identity can be so twisted that the person whom those efforts were directed at may not even notice whom they are fighting in the end – their oppressor or themselves. The story of an American woman opposing the Equal Rights Amendment (ERA) that would guarantee equal rights for all American citizens regardless of sex is depicted in an FX miniseries *Mrs. America* [Dahvi Waller, 2020]. The series is centered around a movement to ratify the ERA and a successful campaign against it led by conservative activist Phyllis Schlafly. Schlafly focused her opposition on the idea of defending traditional roles, such as only men fighting in war as Schlafly argued that the ERA would make women equally required to serve in combat. She received support from housewives who were afraid they would have been forced to find a job alongside continuing to take care of the house, children, and the husband. After stopping the ERA from being ratified, Schlafly hoped for a position in Reagan’s administration but was denied because she was too ‘polarizing.’ Phyllis Schlafly (as depicted in the series) is a meticulously crafted product of a patriarchal society that used her in a fight against her own interests. Throughout the series, she is shown as an energetic and smart woman who overcomes prejudice from fellow male colleagues. However, her sense of self is so distorted to an extent when she does not realize that she has chosen the wrong way to present all her great qualities to the world and prove that a woman is so much more than just a housewife and a supplement to a man. Gloria Steinem, a pro-ERA activist, noticed something quite ironic about real-life Phyllis Schlafly – in Schlafly’s role as an advocate for the full-time mother and wife, she herself was a lawyer, newsletter editor, touring speaker, and political activist [Anti-ERA Evangelist Wins Again, 1978] – which further indicates a huge gap between the way she wants to live her life and the way her political activity restricts other women from doing so.

Otherness being ‘a fundamental category of human thought’ [3] is used not only to define an opposing group of people but also to orchestrate cognitive dissonance within the human’s identity. Otherness from outside induces the Otherness inside, thus creating a completely alien and twisted understanding of the Self which can be used against a person with the intention to destroy them from within. The preservation of the union between the personal identity and one’s desires, social identity, physical attributes is one of the things humans struggle to achieve. The reason for that is because the society values people’s turmoil too highly as it can be used by higher institutions

in their interest. Social distinction can lead to internal alienation as seen on the examples of such phenomena as internalized homophobia or internalized misogyny. Otherness will probably always prevail over sameness, but within we shall stay as the One.

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